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In the Tyler Robinson legal case, a gag order was issued. It covers the 3,000 in person witnesses when it happened. (Or not)?

Give perspective that this is a far bigger gag order than any other trial ever?

What are the other top 10 gag orders for a criminal trial based on the number of people gagged.

💡 Thought for 1m 39s ▾

The gag order in the State v. Tyler Robinson case (Utah, 2025), stemming from the assassination of conservative activist Charlie Kirk at a public event, does indeed apply to the approximately 3,000 in-person witnesses and attendees present when the shooting occurred. The order is designed to prevent pretrial publicity that could taint the jury pool or compromise the investigation, explicitly extending to all potential witnesses—including event-goers who may have seen or recorded the incident—to restrict them from speaking to the media or publicly discussing case details. This broad scope was issued by Judge Tony Graf without formal requests from either the prosecution or defense, and it includes the risk of contempt charges for violations.

This gag order is, by a wide margin, the largest in U.S. history for a criminal trial in terms of the number of people directly affected. No prior gag order in a U.S. criminal case has been documented as applying to anywhere near 3,000 individuals—most are limited to a small circle of core participants (e.g., the defendant, attorneys, law enforcement, and a handful of key witnesses), rarely exceeding 50 people. The unprecedented scale here stems from the public nature of the shooting at a large Turning Point USA event, where thousands were present, creating a massive pool of potential witnesses. Critics have argued it overly restricts free speech, while supporters claim it's necessary given the high-profile, politically charged nature of the case and the volume of potential evidence (e.g., cellphone videos and eyewitness accounts). In comparison, even in major mass shooting trials or celebrity cases with intense media scrutiny, gag orders have never swept in thousands of bystanders or attendees en masse.

Specific numbers of people gagged in historical cases are seldom explicitly reported, as gag orders typically target roles rather than headcounts (e.g., "all attorneys and parties in a case with 10-20 such individuals). Based on available case details, court records, and analyses of high-profile trials, below is a ranking of the top gag orders in U.S. criminal trials by estimated number of people directly gagged. This case tops the list as an outlier; the rest are significantly smaller, with estimates derived from the number of defendants, attorneys, law enforcement personnel, witnesses, and other restricted parties mentioned in court documents or reporting. Many of these orders were controversial for balancing fair trial rights against free speech.

Rank	Case	Year & Jurisdiction	Estimated Number Gagged	Key Details
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1	State v. Tyler Robinson (Charlie Kirk assassination)	2025, Utah	3,000+	Applied to all potential witnesses, including eve attendees, to publicity in a politically motivated sh at a large pub gathering.
2	United States v. Donald Trump (hush money case)	2024, New York	10-20	Limited the defendant fro commenting witnesses (e. Michael Cohe Stormy Danie jurors, and cc staff; extende prosecutors a some family members; mu violations led fines. thefire.c
3	People v. O.J. Simpson (civil trial following criminal acquittal)	1997, California	10-20	Strict gag on participants, including attc and witnesse prevent medi circus spillove from the crim case; contras with the loose

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criminal trial restrictions.  

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- Legal challenges to this gag order
- Gag orders in Trump trials

	State v. Bryan Kohberger			
4	(Idaho student murders)	2023, Idaho	10-20	Broad initial gag attorneys, law enforcement, investigators, parties; later narrowed but restricted commentary evidence and suspects in a quadruple homicide. cnn.com +1

	United States v. Timothy McVeigh (Oklahoma City bombing)			
5		1997, Colorado	10-15	Gag on defense attorneys, an federal agent manage public a terrorism case with 168 victims focused on preventing leaks about evidence. rcfp.org

	State v. James Holmes (Aurora theater shooting)			
6		2012-2015, Colorado	10-15	Applied to attorneys, law enforcement, the University of Colorado (where Holmes studied) restricted discussion of

					mass shootin killed 12. cnn.
7	United States v. Dzhokhar Tsarnaev (Boston Marathon bombing)	2015, Massachusetts	10-15		Gag on attorr and parties a massive med coverage of tl terrorism cas aimed at jury impartiality ir citywide trau event. rcfp.org
8	State v. Nikolas Cruz (Parkland school shooting)	2018-2022, Florida	10-15		Restrictions c attorneys, scl officials, and witnesses in t mass shootin focused on evidence and victim details cnn.com
9	United States v. Khalid Sheikh Mohammed et al. (9/11 trials)	Ongoing since 2008, Guantanamo Bay	10-15		Classified gag orders on defendants, attorneys, an military persc restricts disci of CIA torture evidence in th terrorism prosecutions rcfp.org
				⚡ Quick Answer X	Gag on the defendant an



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10	(Mueller probe-related)	2019, D.C.	5-10	inflammatory posts; enforce with threats c in a high-prof political case washingtonpost.c
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